Traditional Chinese Medicine at Tong Keow Healthcare

Localisation everyday care and pattern differentiation

GEC1044 Group Fieldwork Report • Revised complete draft

TD3 Group 2
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Revision note

This revision retains the presentation's fieldwork findings within the thematic analysis of everyday care, convenience and localisation. It distinguishes evidence from interpretation and treats industry examples as promotional or journalistic rather than peer-reviewed studies. The analysis now tests retail associations against contrasting ginseng profiles, separates cultural contact from shared therapeutic understanding, and connects access mechanisms to the chain and neighbourhood context. Chinese typography, explicit appendix numbering, illustrated five-column tables and APA 7 references are retained. The group presentation and Google Doc template are unchanged.

1 Introduction

Tong Keow's Hougang outlet provides a small-scale case of **continuity through adaptation** in Traditional Chinese Medicine (TCM). Our field photographs show medicinal materials and packaged soups within a shop selling everyday foods. The staff member described nourishment, throat comfort, fatigue and lifestyle concerns as reasons for purchasing herbs and prepared products. This is our interpretation: TCM becomes usable through familiar meals, selected ingredients and convenient formats that change how consumers encounter traditional knowledge. These adaptations help explain access to TCM without establishing the effectiveness of any treatment or the beliefs of individual customers.

The report asks how that accessibility is produced. Everyday food therapy places herbs within household routines; convenience changes the work needed to select and prepare them; and localisation concerns retail organisation, processing, packaging and cultural contact. These themes deepen the presentation's account of preventive care, generational differences and local adaptation. The detailed survey record is preserved in Appendix A so that the analysis can follow the relationships among findings rather than the order of questionnaire requirements.

Our critical concept is **pattern differentiation and treatment according to the identified pattern 辨证论治**.

Retail language can associate fatigue with a tonic or a cold with a familiar remedy, but an individual treatment decision requires assessment of the person's configuration of signs and symptoms. The same format can therefore widen access while simplifying the reasoning through which a remedy is selected. We investigate that tension without presenting this retail visit as an observed clinical consultation.

2 Fieldwork method and the neighbourhood medicine hall

2.1 Sources and levels of evidence

We observed the shop, photographed displays and conducted a semi-structured interview with one staff member on 13 September 2026. The group presentation organises the fieldwork record; the interview transcripts, presentation script and photographs are used to check its claims. Because the transcripts contain recognition errors, we paraphrase clear statements rather than invent exact quotations. References to "the staff member" below refer to this interview (Tong Keow staff member, personal communication, September 13, 2026). Reports about other TCM institutions provide structural comparison only and are not evidence of our own patient encounters.

Staff reports document the interviewee's descriptions of demand, clientele and sourcing. **Direct observations** identify what photographs and displays visibly show. **Our interpretations** connect those findings to course concepts; they are marked explicitly. **Secondary evidence** is cited where it establishes historical, demographic, regulatory or industry context. We obtained no numerical sales records, customer survey, clinical case notes or supply-chain documentation. "Commonly sold" and "popular" retain the presentation's terminology but do not mean a verified twelve-month sales ranking.

2.2 Tong Keow history and its mixed retail model

The presentation dates the original Toa Payoh shop to 1968; a directory's account of its fiftieth anniversary in 2018 supports that reported heritage. ACRA records distinguish Tong Keow Medicine and Provision Shop, registered on 29 March 1975, from Tong Keow Medical Hall Pte. Ltd., incorporated on 1 January 2015; succession between them was not documented. Both list 70 Lorong 4 Toa Payoh #01-333, Toa Payoh Vista, as their registered address. Their primary and secondary activity codes, 47723 and 47102, correspond to Chinese medicine shops and mini-marts, convenience stores and provision shops. These records support a mixed retail classification, not a verified headquarters or warehouse (Accounting and Corporate Regulatory Authority [ACRA], n.d.; Healthcare.com.sg, n.d.; Singapore Department of Statistics [DOS], n.d.).

The tutor identifies Tong Keow as a chain, and the directory links its Toa Payoh and Hougang outlets. The photographs directly show herbs, soup packs, grains and other foods, including Tong Keow branding. This is our interpretation: the mixed retail model places medicinal and culinary shopping within one neighbourhood business, while the chain format raises the possibility of shared purchasing and product presentation. We did not compare branches, interview management or inspect purchasing records. Common branding establishes visual identity; shared procurement and central assembly remain unverified explanations for the Hougang shelves.

2.3 Hougang context and the reported customer base

The staff member described the clientele as mainly Chinese, middle-aged and older, including people in their forties and fifties. Official neighbourhood figures provide a context for that impression, with different geographical units kept separate. Hougang planning area had 228,140 residents in June 2024. HDB reported 57,557 dwelling units managed in Hougang and 165,450 residents housed in its flats as at 31 March 2024. The planning-area total includes other housing and is not interchangeable with the HDB-town figure (DOS, 2024; Housing & Development Board [HDB], 2024, pp. 11–12).

In the official June 2025 table, Hougang Central subzone has 4,620 residents. Using official rounded age-band totals, approximately 1,070 residents are aged 65 or above, or about 23% of the population. The figures are

rounded to the nearest ten; the subzone provides neighbourhood context rather than a measured catchment for the shop (DOS, 2025).

An older-adult study offers a separate view of established neighbourhood life. Among 647 Hougang respondents, 17% lived alone, compared with 15% among 552 respondents in Taman Jurong; the difference was not statistically significant. The Hougang respondents had an average age of 69 and residential tenure of 22 years. These are sample characteristics, not evidence that 17% of Singapore's solitary older residents live in Hougang or that solitary living causes medicine-hall purchases (Chua et al., 2025). This is our interpretation: long residence and repeated use of local amenities provide a plausible setting for familiar neighbourhood retail relationships, although the study did not measure purchases at Tong Keow.

NHB's history of Tou Mu Kung records a Teochew community in Hougang associated with fishing, farming and rubber cultivation (National Heritage Board [NHB], n.d.). This supplies historical context for the presentation's discussion of Chinese medicine within local community life. It does not establish the dialect identity of current customers. This is our interpretation: established housing, a substantial older population and Chinese community history make the staff's account contextually intelligible. They cannot demonstrate causation, determine consumer preferences by ethnicity or show that every visitor lives nearby. The reported forty- and fifty-year-old clientele also cannot be equated with the demographic category aged 65 and over.

3 Everyday care and food therapy

3.1 Medicinal materials within household nourishment

The presentation's eight common-herb entries are ginseng/American ginseng, Dang Shen, Huang Qi, Yu Zhu, Huai Shan, red dates, goji and monk fruit. Table A1 retains these entries while separating the two ginseng materials into distinct reference profiles. The staff member described Dang Shen, Huang Qi, Yu Zhu, Huai Shan, red dates and goji as common soup ingredients. This is evidence of their reported use in cooking, not a complete prescription. The photographs show prepared ingredient packs and a family cooking image on the soup display (Figures 1–2). They corroborate a domestic food setting without establishing how often households cook or consume these preparations.

This is our interpretation: the overlap between herbs and familiar foods gives medicinal vocabulary an ordinary setting. **Nourishing life 养生** concerns everyday maintenance, while the idea of **medicine and food sharing a source 药食同源** helps describe the movement of materials between nourishment and treatment. An ingredient does not automatically perform the same role in every preparation. Lim et al.'s (2005) earlier survey of complementary and alternative medicine in multiracial Singapore provides evidence that health maintenance was a significant use context; it does not supply present-day sales or customer data for our outlet. Yang's (2022) history similarly places Chinese medicine within changing community and institutional arrangements. These sources contextualise the field account rather than verify its product claims.

3.2 Soup packs and the meanings of light replenishment

The presentation names Qing Bu Liang 清补凉, Dang Shen–Huang Qi soup 党参北芪补气汤, Yu Zhu–Huai Shan soup 玉竹淮山润燥汤, goji–red date soup 枸杞红枣养生汤 and Five Finger Fig soup 五指毛桃健脾汤. Table A4 preserves all five and distinguishes named ingredients from unknown complete recipes. The interview supplied an ingredient list rather than five fully documented formulas; the photographs do not independently confirm every presentation label. This qualification keeps the written report aligned with the slides while making the evidential status of their synthesis explicit.

The staff member and presentation associated these soups with maintenance, digestion, moistening and **light replenishment 清补**, rather than intensive tonification 大补. This is our interpretation: such positioning makes replenishment compatible with ordinary meals, without requiring consumers to describe themselves as patients. The Five Phases association of Earth with the Spleen helps explain traditional digestive-support language; Wood and the Liver help contextualise the mood-related language discussed later. These refer to TCM functional relations, not direct equivalents of biomedical organs (World Health Organization [WHO], 2022). Soup labels and functional vocabulary describe intended use; they do not demonstrate a diagnosed pattern, a recovery outcome or a clinically appropriate dose.

3.3 Climate as a retail explanation rather than a diagnosis

The staff member linked monk fruit's popularity and lighter soups to Singapore's environment. MSS describes an equatorial climate with high temperatures, abundant rainfall and high humidity throughout the year, with monsoon and inter-monsoon periods (Meteorological Service Singapore [MSS], n.d.). That is an independently documented climatic background. It does not independently verify the staff's explanation of sales. The phrase "without four distinct seasons" in the presentation is therefore treated as a broad description of tropical conditions rather than a claim that Singapore lacks seasonal weather variation.

The course reading of the Suwen relates seasonal conduct to the maintenance of health (Unschuld & Tessenow, 2011, pp. 45–57). This is our interpretation: the staff's account shows environmental reasoning being adapted from a seasonal vocabulary to an equatorial retail setting. It remains a situated interpretation. High ambient heat does not mean every individual has a heat pattern; high humidity does not establish dampness in every body. Yu Zhu's moistening association is not synonymous with eliminating dampness.

辨证论治 requires the person's signs and circumstances to justify selection, so climatic context cannot substitute for individual assessment.

4 Convenience and changing consumption forms

4.1 Generational accounts and redistributed preparation

The staff member described younger customers as buying fewer raw herbs and preferring teas, supplements and simpler preparations. The eight categories in Table A2 retain exactly the presentation's list: ginseng tonics, monk-fruit products, flower/herbal teas, soup packs, Lingzhi supplements, liver-care/mood-support products, Yin Qiao-type remedies and medicated oils. We did not interview consumers or measure purchases by age. The generational account is therefore staff testimony about this outlet, not evidence that all young Singaporeans have the same preference or have abandoned traditional medicine.

The photographs show preselected dried packs, packaged goods and a multi-buy promotion. Selection and portioning have already been performed for the buyer, but the photographed soups still require cooking. This is our interpretation: convenience redistributes effort rather than necessarily eliminating it. A packer selects the combination, staff explain its purpose and a household completes preparation. A ready-to-drink tea would shift brewing to the seller, whereas a capsule changes both preparation and consumption. We did not confirm a ready-to-drink range at Tong Keow. This distinction develops the slides' convenience argument without adding an unobserved product to the field inventory.

4.2 Comparative industry examples

These comparative industry examples are promotional or journalistic accounts, not peer-reviewed studies. NYP describes Heng Foh Tong's redesign of herbal drinks for millennials (Nanyang Polytechnic [NYP], n.d.). Amacha markets TCM-inspired milk teas; a founder interview claims over 150,000 cups sold in eight months, without audited or age-disaggregated data (Amacha, n.d.; Angelynn T., 2026). Teck Soon's owner reported a 30% sales increase after replacing drawer storage with storefront herb displays in 1982 (Chin, 2024). Eu Yan Sang's halal category illustrates dietary accessibility, not Tong Keow certification (Eu Yan Sang, n.d.). What these accounts do document is that businesses deliberately redesign formats and presentation to change how customers encounter herbal goods. This is our interpretation: that documented strategy makes the presentation's convenience theme analytically plausible; national youth preferences and its effect on Tong Keow purchases remain unmeasured.

4.3 Lifestyle language and what lower demand reveals

The staff member associated late nights, long work hours, stress and prolonged phone use with liver-care or mood-support preparations. This is our interpretation: wellness marketing can turn a diffuse lifestyle concern into a familiar product choice, linking the presentation's account of pressure to its account of convenient forms. We did not verify causal links or diagnose customers. The photograph identifies a Nature's Green example; its connection to the staff's exact preparation remains unconfirmed. 疏肝解郁 describes soothing Liver-related constraint in a TCM vocabulary; it does not itself establish depression treatment or a biomedical hepatic disorder.

National labour data also qualify a simple story of ever-increasing work intensity. MOM reported average usual weekly working hours of 41.4 among employed residents in 2025, down from 44.2 a decade earlier (Ministry of Manpower [MOM], 2026). An average does not describe each customer's schedule or stress. It provides context while preventing us from turning staff accounts of pressure into an unsupported claim that national working hours are continually rising. Preparation effort, work routines and product use would need to be studied together through customer interviews before this suggested relationship could be tested.

The presentation's low-demand examples are Ban Zhi Lian 半枝莲, specialist herbs requiring combinations and strong tonic formulas 大补方. Table A5 retains one named material and two categories, rather than inventing three ranked herbs. The staff member linked lower appeal to unfamiliarity, preparation and the need for guidance; the presentation also linked strong tonics to climatic suitability. This is our interpretation: reduced demand for a more demanding format need not imply rejection of TCM as a whole. The staff also described stocking less of poorly selling items, so observed availability is partly selected by the retailer and cannot independently validate a bottom-three ranking.

5 Localisation through processing packaging and cultural contact

5.1 Separating cultivation manufacture and retail selection

The staff member described raw materials as coming mainly from China, citing variety and cost, and described limited local cultivation. Cactus 仙人掌, roselle 洛神花, patent medicines 中成药, Five Flower Tea 五花茶 and monk-fruit tea 罗汉果茶 remain the five locally linked examples in Table A3. These are not five verified Singapore-grown products. The supplied photograph identifies Nature's Green Mind Soothe Capsules as an example of the finished-medicine category, without proving it was the unnamed preparation meant by the staff member. Secondary evidence from the Health Sciences Authority (HSA) lists this product as a Chinese

Proprietary Medicine manufactured by Tong Jum Chew in Singapore (HSA, 2025b); its ingredient origins remain unverified. Statements about climatic limits on cultivation and the relative cost of Chinese supply remain the interviewee's explanations, not an agronomic or price comparison conducted by the group.

The photographs show Tong Keow branding, selected soup materials and geographical labels on the cabinet. This is our interpretation: localisation can occur at several stages, including assembling ingredients into a familiar soup, portioning, naming and presenting them for local use. Visible branding supports retail adaptation. It does not establish the place where a specific ingredient was grown or a pack was assembled. This distinction refines the presentation's statement that imported materials are processed and packaged locally: that account is retained as staff-reported, while the soup packs' local processing remains unverified.

Singapore's Chinese Proprietary Medicines (CPM) framework establishes that local manufacture and assembly are formal regulated activities. HSA's dealer guidance requires the relevant licences for importing and wholesale supply, and a valid manufacturer's licence and GMP compliance for local manufacturing or assembly facilities. Its consumer guidance includes re-packers among regulated dealers and requires product listing before a CPM is imported, manufactured or sold (Health Sciences Authority [HSA], 2026c, 2026d). These obligations concern finished Chinese Proprietary Medicines and the activities performed by a dealer. They do not automatically classify every raw herb, food, tea or soup pack as a CPM, or prove that Tong Keow operates a licensed assembly facility. We did not audit its licences or identified products.

5.2 Packaging as regulatory and cultural translation

HSA's CPM listing guidelines require full labelling in English and allow additional languages, whose text must correspond to the English information. Required particulars include product and ingredient information, batch and expiry details, with relevant manufacturer, importer or assembler details on outer packaging (HSA, 2025a, section 5). These requirements show how a finished medicinal product must become legible within Singapore's regulatory setting. Listing is not evidence that its therapeutic effects have been proven (HSA, 2026b). The photographs of Tong Keow packs establish branding and packaged form, but our images and records are insufficient for a complete bilingual label or compliance audit.

A packaging study provides a regional comparison rather than Singapore-specific field evidence. Liu et al. (2026) examined Chinese herbal medicines sold in Malaysia and showed how legal constraints shape translated product names and therapeutic statements. Their account helps frame translation as a negotiation between medical vocabulary, permissible claims and consumer communication. Malaysia's rules and sampled products cannot substitute for HSA requirements or evidence about Tong Keow's labels. This is our interpretation: packaging can alter how inherited knowledge is encountered, but changes in language, dosage form or branding alone do not establish that a customer understands the underlying pattern logic.

Quality language also affects that encounter. The staff member emphasised fresh colour, visible freshness and sulphur-free materials. Figure 3 shows the sulphur-free Dang Shen claim and separate American ginseng label. It verifies the presence of the claims rather than production methods, authenticity or safety. HSA's supplement-claims guidance rejects the implication that natural origin guarantees safety (HSA, 2026a). This is our interpretation: reassuring labels can support retail trust, but neither a quality claim nor convenient packaging resolves individual suitability under 辨证论治.

5.3 A shared shopping space and differing meanings of use

The staff member described Malay customers buying dessert ingredients and Indian customers buying nuts, alongside a largely Chinese clientele. We did not independently identify customers' ethnicity or ask them

about medical beliefs. The photographs show a product mix compatible with culinary shopping, but cannot verify the reported purchasing pattern. This is our interpretation: the medicine hall's combined food and medicinal range offers reasons for contact across cultural boundaries. Buying a dessert ingredient in this space does not show acceptance of Qi, meridians or pattern differentiation.

This is our interpretation: a shared retail space can support everyday contact without requiring shared therapeutic interpretation. Here cultural adaptation concerns the range of uses attached to the medicine hall: a culinary purchase can coexist with a wellness purchase while drawing on different meanings. Cultural accessibility may therefore expand through overlapping routines rather than agreement about Qi or meridians. The reported purchases identify routes into that shared space; they do not demonstrate interaction between customers or a historical shift in their beliefs.

6 Pattern differentiation and continuity through adaptation

6.1 Retail associations and the assessment they cannot replace

WHO defines the four examinations 望闻问切 as inspection, listening and smelling, inquiry and palpation; the findings inform pattern differentiation and treatment selection (WHO, 2022). This is our interpretation: the essential distinction is between recognising a complaint and assessing its configuration within an individual. Table A6 records retail associations, without an observed examination, justified pattern, dose or treatment duration. Those associations cannot substitute for clinical assessment or establish that 辨证论治 occurred.

The staff's fatigue pairing with ginseng or Dang Shen in Table A6 illustrates the gap. The presentation groups ginseng and American ginseng, but Table A1 distinguishes the former's neutral nature from the latter's cool nature and Yin-nourishing functions (The Hong Kong Polytechnic University [PolyU], n.d.-a, n.d.-h). This is our interpretation: fatigue alone identifies neither the relevant pattern nor which profile, if either, suits a person.

This is our interpretation: format does not determine individualisation. A prepared product can follow clinical assessment, and raw herbs can be bought without one; climate supplies context rather than an individual diagnosis. The decisive evidence is a documented connection between assessed signs and treatment selection, which this visit did not provide.

6.2 Connecting everyday routines formats and local institutions

This is our interpretation: everyday care, convenience and localisation form connected mechanisms of access. Food use supplies the household setting; preselected packs reduce ingredient-selection work while retaining cooking; local branding and product information present materials in recognisable forms. The mechanisms reinforce one another: familiar use gives selection a purpose, while packaging carries that intended use into the shop and home. Adaptation also redistributes expertise among producers, staff, household cooks, consumers and, where involved, clinicians. None of these mechanisms alone establishes that consumers understand the pattern logic behind a product or receive individually appropriate treatment.

Sections 2.2–2.3 make the setting part of the explanation. The mixed business classification and branded display connect medicinal–culinary retail to Tong Keow's organisational identity. Hougang's established housing and older population, with long residence in the study sample, contextualise the staff-described clientele. This is our interpretation: branding links the branch to a wider business, while household food and wellness routines give the model a neighbourhood setting. These conditions help explain its local fit; shared procurement, repeat purchasing and their causal weights remain unmeasured.

This account follows Unschuld's (2018) emphasis on selection and adaptation and Yang's (2022) history of Singapore's community and professional institutions. This is our interpretation: the medicine hall adds a retail mechanism to that history. 辨证论治 provides the critical distinction between making inherited knowledge accessible and documenting an individually justified treatment decision.

7 Limitations and remaining evidence gaps

This study covers one visit, one staff interview and one outlet. Common-seller and lower-demand lists are unranked reports, without sales totals or a verified twelve-month period; customer age, ethnicity and motives were not measured. Neighbourhood figures use different geographical boundaries, and the older-adult study concerns a sample rather than the shop's catchment. Promotional and journalistic industry examples demonstrate particular strategies, not causal effects, national preferences or Tong Keow customer behaviour. They are contextual comparisons, distinct from academic research and official statistics.

Item-level sourcing, complete soup recipes and chain purchasing arrangements remain unverified. HSA corroborates Singapore manufacture of the pictured Nature's Green capsules; the ingredient origins and whether this was the preparation intended in the interview remain unverified. The presentation's 1968 heritage account is distinguished from registration dates, and climatic explanations are not individual diagnoses. An in-house physician was not clearly confirmed: physician availability and the clinical survey requirements remain not established, rather than evidence of absence. MOH describes professional registration, but the interview establishes neither the staff member's credentials nor an assessed clinical encounter (Ministry of Health [MOH], 2026). Follow-up would require product labels, sourcing records, branch comparisons, customer data and documented consultations.

MOH reported that nearly 40% of TCM users in the 2022 National Population Health Survey combined TCM and Western medicine for the same condition (MOH, 2025). This contextual figure does not establish our customers' treatment choices or motivations. External reference images in Tables A1, A2 and A5 add no observed stock; neither those images nor the field photographs establish therapeutic efficacy, regulatory compliance, botanical authenticity or a community's medical beliefs.

8 Conclusion

At Tong Keow, TCM is made usable through household nourishment, redistributed preparation and a neighbourhood shop that combines medicinal and culinary retail. The fieldwork's herbs, soups, product categories and staff accounts show the concrete settings through which people encounter it; the thematic analysis connects those settings rather than treating the survey as a sequence of answers.

This is our interpretation: continuity is sustained through adapting ways of access and settings of use, rather than preserving raw-material forms alone. Yet adaptation is not 辨证论治. Retail associations make products intelligible, while an individual treatment decision requires assessed signs and justified selection. The report's central contribution is to explain how TCM becomes usable while keeping that clinical distinction visible.

Appendix A Detailed fieldwork evidence

These records preserve the presentation's substantive inventory. A1–A5 correspond to former Sections 3.1–3.5; the questionnaire sequence is retained here for checking completeness, while Sections 3–5 supply the thematic analysis. Traditional applications are reference information or reported positioning, not evidence of clinical efficacy.

A1 Eight herb entries with separate reference profiles

The presentation groups ginseng and American ginseng in one entry. Nine reference rows therefore represent eight reported entries, not a ninth seller or an annual ranking. The field cabinet independently labels American ginseng.

Table A1 Traditional herb profiles in the eight presentation entries

Herb	Nature & Flavour	Meridian	Function	Application
 人参 *Ren Shen* Ginseng (root) (PolyU, n.d.-h)	Sweet, slightly bitter; neutral	Heart, Spleen, Lung	Strongly tonifies original Qi; supports Spleen and Lung; generates fluids; calms the spirit.	Poor appetite, fatigue and breathlessness in Qi-deficiency patterns; thirst from fluid depletion.
 西洋参 *Xi Yang Shen* American ginseng (root) (PolyU, n.d.-a)	Sweet, slightly bitter; cool	Heart, Lung, Kidney	Tonifies Qi and nourishes Yin; clears heat; generates fluids.	Fatigue, dry mouth, thirst and cough in Qi–Yin deficiency with deficiency heat.
 党参 *Dang Shen* Codonopsis (root) (PolyU, n.d.-m)	Sweet; neutral	Spleen, Lung	Tonifies middle Qi; strengthens Spleen and Lung functions.	Poor appetite, loose stools, fatigue and shortness of breath in Spleen–Lung Qi deficiency.
 黄芪 *Huang Qi* Astragalus / milkvetch (root) (PolyU, n.d.-l)	Sweet; warm	Spleen, Lung	Tonifies Qi; strengthens exterior defence; promotes fluid discharge and tissue repair.	Fatigue, poor appetite and loose stools in Qi deficiency; spontaneous sweating from weak exterior defence.

Herb	Nature & Flavour	Meridian	Function	Application
 玉竹 *Yu Zhu* Fragrant Solomon's seal (rhizome) (PolyU, n.d.-g)	Sweet; slightly cold	Lung, Stomach	Nourishes Yin; moistens dryness; generates fluids and relieves thirst.	Dry cough, dry throat and thirst in Lung–Stomach Yin deficiency.
 淮山 / 山药 *Huai Shan / Shan Yao* Chinese yam (rhizome) (PolyU, n.d.-f)	Sweet; neutral	Spleen, Lung, Kidney	Supports Spleen and Stomach; generates fluids and benefits Lung; strengthens Kidney.	Poor appetite and persistent diarrhoea in Spleen deficiency; chronic cough in Lung deficiency; frequent urination in Kidney deficiency.
 红枣 / 大枣 *Hong Zao / Da Zao* Red dates / jujube (fruit) (PolyU, n.d.-d)	Sweet; warm	Spleen, Stomach	Tonifies middle Qi; nourishes Blood; calms the spirit.	Poor appetite, tiredness and loose stools in Spleen-deficiency patterns.
 枸杞子 *Gou Qi Zi* Goji / wolfberry (fruit) (PolyU, n.d.-b)	Sweet; neutral	Liver, Kidney	Nourishes Liver and Kidney; replenishes essence; supports vision.	Dizziness, aching lower back and knees, and impaired vision in Liver–Kidney deficiency patterns.
 罗汉果 *Luo Han Guo* Monk fruit (fruit) (PolyU, n.d.-j)	Sweet; cool	Lung, Large Intestine	Clears heat; moistens Lung; lubricates the intestines.	Dry cough, sore throat and hoarseness in Lung-heat dryness; constipation from intestinal dryness.

Note. Reference photographs and traditional profiles are adapted from the Hong Kong Polytechnic University database (PolyU); they were not photographed at Tong Keow. Meridian names refer to TCM functional systems. Applications depend on assessed patterns, not a symptom alone.

A2 Eight reported product categories with illustrations

The eight categories follow presentation slide 4. The supplied photograph identifies Nature's Green Mind Soothe Capsules as an example, while formulas and sales ranks remain unverified. The five-column layout follows Table A1; an ingredient's profile is not assigned to an unidentified finished product.

Table A2 Illustrated profiles of the eight presentation product categories

Product or category	Nature & Flavour	Meridian	Function	Application
 **Ginseng tonics** 人参 / 西洋参	Varies by formula.	Not recorded.	Staff linked use to fatigue, Qi support and immunity.	Age-specific purchases were not measured.
 **罗汉果 Monk-fruit products** Reference material: monk fruit (PolyU, n.d.-j)	Reference fruit: sweet and cool.	Reference fruit: Lung and Large Intestine.	Staff associated it with throat comfort and cooling.	Fruit and drink forms were described, with recipes unrecorded.
 **花茶 / 凉茶 Flower and herbal teas** Reference flower: chrysanthemum (PolyU, n.d.-e)	Mixture not recorded.	Mixture not recorded.	Staff described everyday wellness uses.	Staff linked simple brewing to younger buyers.
 **药材汤包 Soup packs** Fieldwork soup display 13 September 2026	Complete recipe unknown.	Formula not recorded.	Presentation: light nourishment.	Preselected dried packs still require cooking.

Product or category	Nature & Flavour	Meridian	Function	Application
 **灵芝保健品** **Lingzhi supplements** Reference: Lingzhi (PolyU, n.d.-i)	Supplement formula unknown.	Whole-product affinities unrecorded.	Staff associated supplements with immunity support.	No immune response or clinical outcome was measured.
 **养肝 / 疏肝解郁** Nature's Green 绿叶 Mind Soothe Capsules Supplied photograph	Formula not recorded.	Whole-product affinities unrecorded.	Staff described Liver nourishment and soothing constraint; the box uses "Mind Soothe" language.	Staff linked use to late nights and stress; the photograph identifies an example, without clinical assessment.
 **银翘类** **Yin Qiao-type remedies** Reference: honeysuckle (PolyU, n.d.-k)	Exact formula unidentified.	Whole-product affinities unrecorded.	Staff associated this category with cold symptoms.	The retail association has no recorded patient assessment.
 **红花油 / 红油精** **Medicated oils** External example (Fei Fah, n.d.)	Topical formula unidentified.	No meridian assigned.	Staff associated oils with aches and injuries.	Staff described external use, including by older customers.

Note. Uses follow the interview or presentation. The supplied Nature's Green photograph identifies the illustrated product; other reference illustrations do not verify stock. The front label does not establish its formula, efficacy or clinical suitability.

A3 Five locally linked examples and production status

The five locally linked examples distinguish cultivation, manufacture, processing, packing and branding. Nature's Green is a brand, not a locality category. Its pictured Mind Soothe Capsules are classified here as a Singapore-manufactured finished Chinese Proprietary Medicine, corroborated by HSA's product list (HSA, 2025b), rather than as Singapore-grown herbs.

Table A3 Locally linked examples retained from the presentation

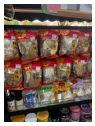
Example	Raw origin and grown in Singapore	Manufacture in Singapore	Processing packaging or brand link
 **Cactus 仙人掌** (NParks, n.d.-b)	Named as a possible locally grown example; origin of stock unknown	Not established	No specific product or producer identified.
 **Roselle 洛神花** (NParks, n.d.-a)	Named as a possible locally grown example; origin of stock unknown	Not established	No specific product or producer identified.
 **Mind Soothe Capsules 舒肝解郁胶囊** Nature's Green 绿叶 Finished CPM	Ingredient origins and Singapore cultivation are unverified.	HSA lists Tong Jum Chew as manufacturer and Singapore as the manufacturing country (HSA, 2025b).	Nature's Green is the brand; this is a finished Chinese Proprietary Medicine, not evidence of local herb cultivation.
 **Five Flower Tea 五花茶** (Wing Joo Loong, n.d.)	Not established	Not established	Locally linked in the presentation; item-specific processor, packer and brand unknown.
 **Monk fruit tea 罗汉果茶** Reference: monk fruit (PolyU, n.d.-j)	Not established for the tea product	Not established	Locally linked in the presentation; item-specific processor, packer and brand unknown.

Note. NParks photographs show reference plants; the interview did not identify a cactus species or stock origins. The Wing Joo Loong image and monk-fruit ingredient image do not identify Tong Keow's tea products. HSA's listing corroborates Singapore manufacture of Mind Soothe Capsules; it does not establish ingredient origins or independently audit the photographed batch.

A4 Five soup therapies retained from the presentation

The five labels match slide 6. The staff separately named Dang Shen, Huang Qi, Yu Zhu, Huai Shan, red dates and goji as common soup ingredients, without supplying five complete recipes. These are maintenance and climatic-wellness positions rather than documented clinical recovery cases.

Table A4 Soup labels ingredients and reported purposes

Soup label	Ingredients available from the record	Purpose and main use
 **Qing Bu Liang 清补凉** Field display context only	Complete recipe not recorded	Light nourishment and climatic wellness; health maintenance in the presentation's interpretation.
  **Dang Shen and Huang Qi soup** **党参北芪补气汤** Named ingredients only	Dang Shen and Huang Qi are named; complete recipe unknown	Qi support and nourishment; maintenance rather than documented clinical recovery.
  **Yu Zhu and Huai Shan soup** **玉竹淮山润燥汤** Named ingredients only	Yu Zhu and Huai Shan are named; complete recipe unknown	Moistening and nourishment; climatic wellness positioning.
  **Goji and red date soup** **枸杞红枣养生汤** Named ingredients only	Goji and red dates are named; complete recipe unknown	Everyday nourishment and health maintenance.
 **Five Finger Fig soup** **五指毛桃健脾汤** Reference root only (DH, n.d.)	Five Finger Fig is named; other ingredients not recorded	Spleen and digestive support in traditional terms; maintenance positioning.

Note. Images show named materials, not complete formulas or finished soups. PolyU supplies Dang Shen, Huang Qi, Yu Zhu, Huai Shan, goji and red dates (n.d.-m, n.d.-l, n.d.-g, n.d.-f, n.d.-b, n.d.-d); Hong Kong's Department of Health (DH, n.d.) supplies Five Finger Fig root. The Qing Bu Liang image shows field display context only.

A5 Three comparatively lower-demand examples with illustrations

This table preserves former Section 3.5 and presentation slide 8. It contains one named herb and two broad categories. Neither a verified bottom-three rank nor three distinct medicinal species was recorded. Broad categories cannot be given a single nature or meridian profile.

Table A5 Illustrated profiles of the lower-demand examples

Product or category	Nature & Flavour	Meridian	Function	Application
 **半枝莲 Ban Zhi Lian** **Barbated skullcup herb** Reference material (PolyU, n.d.-c)	Sweet, bitter and cold.	Liver, Lung and Kidney.	Reference: clears heat and toxins, resolves stasis and promotes urination.	Reference uses include sores, throat swelling and oedema.
 **Specialist herbs** Requiring combinations	Varies by formula.	Varies by formula.	No combination was identified.	Staff described a need for preparation and guidance.
 **大补方** **Strong tonic formulas** Tonic material illustration only (PolyU, n.d.-h)	Formula not recorded.	Formula not recorded.	Presentation: intensive replenishment 大补.	The presentation associated lower appeal with suitability and climate.

Note. Ban Zhi Lian properties are PolyU reference information. The specialist-herb photograph shows the field cabinet only; no second low-demand herb or combination was identified. The ginseng illustration does not identify a strong-tonic formula. Lower demand is staff-reported, not a verified ranking.

A6 Physician evidence and separate retail associations

Physician presence was not clearly confirmed. Accordingly, eight physician prescriptions and eight physician-treated symptoms remain not established. The six associations below are staff-reported retail pairings retained from slide 9. Patient examination, exact formulations, doses and treatment durations were not recorded.

Table A6 Retail symptom associations without confirmed clinical prescriptions

Complaint or wellness concern	Associated retail product	Interpretive qualification
Colds	Yin Qiao type remedies	A broad complaint does not establish the pattern for which a formulation is suitable.
Diarrhoea	Huoxiang Zhengqi type remedies	Staff association; no individual cause or pattern assessed.
Fatigue or Qi deficiency language	Ginseng or Dang Shen	Fatigue alone does not demonstrate Qi deficiency.
Perceived lower immunity	Lingzhi or supplements	Wellness claim rather than measured immune dysfunction.
Late nights stress and long work hours	Liver care or mood support products	Retail lifestyle framing; no liver disease or mental health diagnosis established.
Aches or injuries	Medicated oils	Reported topical retail use; no clinical injury assessment recorded.

Appendix A7 Survey coverage and evidential status

Table A7 Appendix survey coverage and evidence limits

Survey item	Record retained	Location	Evidence limit
A	Eight herb entries; nine reference profiles	A1; Section 3.1	No verified twelve-month sales ranking.
B	Eight product categories	A2; Section 4	Exact products and comparative sales unknown.
C	Five locally linked examples	A3; Section 5.1	Capsule manufacture corroborated; other origins unverified.
D	Five soup labels	A4; Section 3.2	Complete recipes and all pack identities unconfirmed.
E	One named herb and two categories	A5; Section 4.3	No verified bottom-three ranking.
F	Physician prescriptions not established	A6; Section 7	Physician role not confirmed; no clinical cases recorded.
G	Six separate retail associations	A6; Section 6.1	Not eight physician-treated symptoms or case records.

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Appendix B Fieldwork photographs

Figure 1

Soup promotion in the neighbourhood retail setting



Note. The frontage shows branded soup packs and a family cooking image; it does not establish recipes or a sales ranking. Photograph by the group, Tong Keow Healthcare, 13 September 2026.

Figure 2

Preselected dried soup ingredients in branded packs



Note. The display shows preselected dried soup ingredients requiring preparation; it does not confirm all five soup labels or local manufacture. Photograph by the group, Tong Keow Healthcare, 13 September 2026.

Figure 3

Herb labels and retail quality claims



Note. Labels distinguish American ginseng and claim sulphur-free Dang Shen; they do not verify authenticity, production methods or safety. Photograph by the group, Tong Keow Healthcare, 13 September 2026.